about 14 inches high, the largest size found anywhere in the Harappan realm. They must have been legible from the stands across the stadium. For all we know, it could well have said, ‘Save water!’

Walking around, I often spot pottery shards on the ground, some painted, some as large as my palm. They came from pots that were up to one metre tall. I pick up a smooth piece of a stone bangle worn by a Dholaviran four millennia ago. Perhaps a mother scolded her child for breaking it. Dholavira, it appears, was ‘one of the greatest centres for making stone beads’ and has yielded 1270 drill bits and many stone polishers, the largest from any Harappan site.[15] Notably, the castle itself had many bead-making workshops. My guide points out bits of semi-precious stones lying about—carnelian, chert, quartz, chalcedony, serpentine, jasper, agate—many from mines in Kutch. He shows me greenish copper slags from the smelting process used to purify the ore. Children’s toys, whistles, dice, sling balls, hopscotches, game boards carved on stone blocks and even a smoking pipe have been found here. Perhaps then, too, small crowds gathered around players hunched over a board game under a shady tree. Around 225 seals, of steatite (soapstone) and other materials, have been found (soft steatite stones were finely carved, polished and fired in a kiln to harden them). ‘They carted many truckloads of material to Delhi,’ claims the guide, where it now lies in ASI facilities. He also points out some of the bones of animals that the Harappans ate: goat, sheep, cow, buffalo, deer, fish, rabbit, chicken, wild pig, wild ass and more. The Harappans hunted too; seals from many other Harappan sites show ‘encounters with wild and ferocious animals’.[16]

A great mystery surrounds the walls of Dholavira—from its outer city walls to internal walled neighbourhoods. Its city walls are several metres thick; three of its four corner towers have been excavated. But it’s unclear from whom such thick defensive walls were meant to protect the residents. Dholavira was then literally on an island! None of the usual threats—wild animals, enemy states (there were likely none), pirates from the sea, or hostile tribal groups (how many could have been there on the island to be a threat?)—would have required stone walls that are many metres thick and high. Nor are there moats around them. Some speculate that the walls guarded against sea storms and tsunamis, but the walls had gates and weren’t watertight. Perhaps they withstood earthquakes better. Or perhaps